

Internet access via cell phones - slow, sometimes unstable connections that depended too much on network traffic.

Nearly all companies that offer satellite phone services offer dual-mode phones - they can switch between satellite and GSM networks. The customer then doesn't have to bear the high cost of satellite telephony when in an area well-covered by a GSM network. The satellites will take over when he makes that urgent trip to the middle of the Sahara.

There is still a good way to go before the satellite phone becomes ubiquitous, but costs have dropped enough to make them a good deal more feasible.